‘countless great kingdoms of countless great monarchs have suffered devastation and have been razed to dust, but the glorious emergence of the power of benevolence in Asoka has become our proud asset, and is breathing strength into us.’[33] Gandhi’s belief in non-violence, whether consciously or not, derived in part from the Ashokan worldview, and consequently breathed new life into a nearly forgotten political value system that Ashoka had inaugurated. The affinity that Nehru felt for Ashoka, movingly articulated in *The Discovery of India*, bears this out. On the verge of building a modern state in the shadow of Gandhi, it was natural for Nehru to identify with Ashoka.[34] Later, he invoked Ashoka on crucial public occasions—most notably when a resolution about India’s flag was moved in 1947. This made explicit the association of modern Indian democracy with an Ashokan emblem, the Sarnath pillar capitol. When moving the resolution in the Constituent Assembly, Nehru said the presence of the wheel, the Ashoka chakra, made him feel ‘exceedingly happy that in this sense indirectly we have associated with this flag of ours not only this emblem but in a sense the name of Asoka, one of the most magnificent names not only in India’s history but in world history.’[35] With such rhetorical appropriations of antiquity are modern national identities forged and communities imagined, and it could be argued that Ashoka was the ace in Nehru’s pack.

Adding to the charm and excitement of Ashoka was the dramatic way in which he had emerged out of unexpected discoveries and decipherments. Military men, antiquarians, and archaeologists had chanced upon epigraphs in an unknown writing on rocks and pillars in various parts of India in the early decades of the nineteenth century, a discovery saga which has been well told in various works on the evolution of Indian archaeology, most recently in Charles Allen’s narrative history of the discovery of Ashoka.[36] Facsimiles of the objects and writings unearthed—from pillars in North India to rocks in Orissa and Gujarat—found their way to the Asiatic Society